

for art, they would become the troika scouring the bylanes of the city's art district in the Fort area and collecting and mentoring a young generation of artists alight with the flame of what they knew would be the avant garde of the New India still waiting to emerge from its colonial undercurrents. One may take exception to the sub-title. However prescient and powerful Rudolf von Leyden may have been as a catalyst, he was only one of the persons sounding the clarion call to Indian artists of that generation.

Never mind. The fact remains that after aspiring to be a geologist and landing in Bombay, Rudi, as the author calls him, found himself writing art reviews instead. When he began his career in the advertising section of *The Times of India*, he found himself with enough time to trawl the art shows at the famed Taj Mahal Hotel and some of the other downtown venues for art. When in the latter phase of his life he joined the corporate world at Volkart Brothers, he continued to have a toe in the advertising world.

In her elegantly wrought memoir, Reema Desai Gehi places Rudi at the epicentre of the whorl of the city's glitterati. The upper crust of Bombay cosmopolitan elite was dominated by successful mercantile communities eager to establish their credentials as patrons of the arts. Gehi has captured the lightness of being alive in Bombay in the heady years of pre-Independence India.

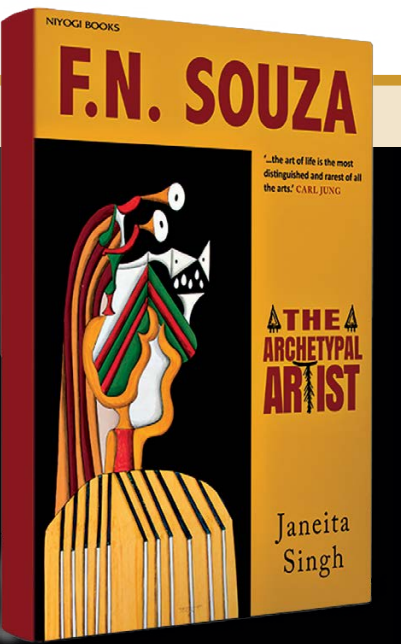
Krishen Khanna, now in his 90s and a vital link to the Progressive Artists' Group (PAG), records what Rudi meant to them in the 'Foreword'. It was a symbiotic relationship. Rudi's championing of the very different individuals of the PAG with their need to find a visionary who could redirect their native energy into a product befitting the nationalist agenda is a part of the narrative on modernism in India.

Rudi championed the different individuals of the Progressive Artists' Group, while they needed a visionary who could redirect their native energy

Gehi has been able to resurrect part of Rudi's trajectory before and after he left his imprint on Bombay by mining a trove of interesting images. There are copies of the letters with quaint line drawings of the India that he was intent on discovering the moment he landed in Bombay, that he wrote to his mother Luise; there's a beautiful painting by his brother Albrecht, of the wooded mansion on Pali Hill where they lived in the early years of exile; his political cartoons under an assumed name skewering the Fuehrer; his first wife Nena's sketches and paintings of the two Coorlawala sisters.

Towards the end of the book, there is a veritable cornucopia of portraits presented to Rudi as he leaves India in 1968 by some of the best-known artists in their prime. It's an album of immortals. Unbeknownst even to him, perhaps, Rudi had become a brand. ■

–Geeta Doctor



F.N. SOUZA
The Archetypal Artist
by Janeita Singh
NIYOGI BOOKS
₹4,500; 320 pages

uces the female body to easily recognisable sub-Picasso/ men's magazine components, Singh brings us back to the correct path in Chapter 1.6: "F.N. Souza resurrected women from the miasma of obsessive obscene sexuality and made them sing." In case we are still not able to hear this singing, there are more pages of Souza nudes leavened with the work of other (arguably lesser) artists like Botticelli, Goya, Indian miniature painters, Cézanne, Egon Schiele and Matisse.

Though it would have been interesting to see Souza's influence on the work of Francis Bacon and the older Picasso, not a page has been wasted on any reproduction by these artists, bolstering the feeling that comparisons are, ultimately, odious.

In 'My Growing up Years in Goa/ Bombay and Early Art – Essay in Souza's Voice...', we get what Banerji calls "...a remarkable ventriloquist act of lending one's voice to the artist in his early life..." Here, Singh gives us her vivid imaginary rendering of Souza's voice: "In spite of the unfavourable situation at home, the larger canvases in my art portfolio in the 1940s display a bright colour palette, an expression of my adoration for my native land in its elemental glory"; and, "I was a germ. And what I have become, a proud artist, the best in the world." One is also caught by the resonance of this sentence by Singh: "Dipping a paintbrush into Souza's psyche, I regard that he painted the body where the duality abides." ■

–Ruchir Joshi